EUROPEAN UNIVERSITY INSTITUTE

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Privacy Statement for the research project 'AI Use and Human Agency in Graduate Education'

28 April 2026

1. Description of the processing operations.

Structured data is collected over a **10-week longitudinal cycle.** This cycle aims to capture the longitudinal evolution of graduate students' **emotional dependency (ED), decision-making independence (DMI), and identity formation (ID) regarding AI.** It employs a concurrent mixed-methods approach comprising quantitative surveys, open-ended reflections, and semi-structured interviews to track both objective usage frequency and the subjective experience of evolving agency. The 10-week study is organised around 3 modules:

1. ***Module I (Baseline Cultural Context);*** establishes the participant's starting point, including regional origin, language background, and cultural attitudes toward technology and cognitive effort to contextualise their initial relationship with AI.
2. ***Module II (Weekly Self-Documentation);*** measures longitudinal shifts through *multiple-choice questions (Quantitative) and open-ended reflections (Qualitative)*. The quantitative portion (QQ) uses repeated questions on 1–5 standardised scales to track trends across the cohort. The qualitative portion features rotating open-ended (OE) questions, for which data controllers select three per week, each representing a different dimension.
3. ***Module III (Semi-structured interviews);*** *provides the qualitative depth necessary to interpret quantitative survey results through in-person or via video conferencing (Microsoft Teams) at Weeks 1, 5, and 10*. These 20-minute sessions break each concept (ED, DMI, and ID) into measurable items and adapt questions to the interview timeline.

The quantitative analysis (Module II – Multiple choice questions) will be assisted by the Qualtrics XM software, notably through its built-in data analysis features. **The qualitative analysis (Module II – open-ended reflections / Module III – open-ended reflections and semi-structured interviews) will be assisted by a locally installed Mistral 2 B**, finetuned using a dedicated codebook to map trends, keywords, and patterns within long-form qualitative responses. The model will be finetuned to perform text analysis. For both tools, the data controllers will validate the generated output to ensure the accuracy of the results. For additional privacy and security measures, the model will only process data that has already been pseudonymised via the PIC methods.

2. What data do we collect, for what purpose(s), and through which technical means?

The project uses a mixed-methods approach, combining quantitative and qualitative data to analyse trends in human-AI dynamics. Quantitative analysis focuses on pre-coded survey data to establish statistical growth, while qualitative analysis examines open-ended responses and semi-structured interviews to provide depth and explanation for the identified trends.

Because the research project aims to analyse patterns of AI-Human interaction among graduate education, the data collected will be exclusively from data subjects (ie, Research Participants) recruited from the student body of the European University Institute (EUI), more particularly **students enrolled in the Master of Arts in Transnational Governance (MTnG) at the School of Transnational Governance (STG)**. **Natural persons typically aged between 20 and 30 years old, currently residing within the EU/EEA (Italy) for the duration of the 10-week longitudinal study.** Participants represent a diverse array of regional origins (mapped via GLOBE Project clusters) and linguistic backgrounds (categorised via Glottolog 5.2) to facilitate the cross-cultural comparative nature of the study.

The collected data consists of subjective views, interpretations, and cognitive positions on AI utility. These serve as empirical indicators for the constructs mentioned above. No sensitive data is collected. The project also collects specific demographic data, namely, Regional Origins and Language Family Background. The processing of these data points is essential to establish scientific inferences regarding how cultural heritage and linguistic structures influence a subject's interaction with AI tools. These variables serve as independent controls to identify cultural variances in the development of ED, DMI, and ID.

Participant data is collected using the following platforms and applications:

- ***Qualtrics XM:*** *used for gathering initial contact information, establishing baseline cultural context, managing weekly self-documentation, and capturing open-ended reflections.*
- ***Apple Voice Memos / Microsoft Teams / aTrain:*** *used for audio recording and transcription of In-person semi-structured interviews. A locally hosted software (Atrain) will be used to transcribe and process semi-structured interview recordings in Word.*

Residual data shared from data subjects to data-controllers via other means, notably via messaging or email, will not be collected and will not serve the analysis.

3. Who has access to your data and to whom it is disclosed?

During the study, access to collected data is strictly limited to the **Data Controllers (*Vladimir SUCHA & Antoine CERQUEIRA DA COSTA*)**. Data will be processed through the following legal persons, acting as **Data Processors**:

- ***Qualtrics, LLC*** *(specifically Qualtrics XM for data collection and analysis);*
- ***Microsoft Corporation*** *(specifically via Microsoft Teams for online interviews, OneDrive for cloud data storage, Microsoft Word and Excel for data processing, and Microsoft Outlook as the primary communication platform for data subjects);*
- ***Apple Inc.*** *(specifically the Apple Voice Memos app for the audio recording of interviews);*

No other external data processors or controllers have access to the data. The tools used for analysis, specifically aTrain and Mistral 2B, are installed locally. These tools do not qualify as "Data Processors" because they are not linked to the cloud; all processing occurs in a closed-source, within the local environment of the data controllers.

However, access to this data by both data controllers and data processors is subject to a strict **pseudonymization procedure** to uphold "Privacy by Design" and prevent the identification of participants by name or contact information. Each respondent creates a **unique PIC (Self-Generated Personal Identifier Code (PIC)).** The data subject is solely responsible for developing, storing, and entering this code. Joint data controllers do not maintain a master key or the capacity to identify participants, as the components of the PIC (e.g., hometown postal code, favorite movie) are not collected elsewhere in the study. Any residual information that could potentially link a respondent to their identity will be immediately deleted to maintain the integrity of the PIC system. The pseudonymization procedure is designed so data subjects can reconstitute their PIC at any time by following instructions, eliminating the need for a formal, traceable record. Traceability only occurs if a subject proactively exercises their Right to Withdrawal or Consultation by providing their PIC to the controllers via email. Despite the low residual re-identification risk enabled by the design and handling of the PIC method, re-identification and traceability remain possible if certain conditions are met (e.g., right to withdrawal, transformation process of audio files). This makes the pseudonymisation process legally distinct from complete anonymisation.

The pseudonymization procedure is explained to participants as follows during the 10 week cycle;

> *"To ensure your responses remain confidential and protected while allowing us to track your participation across this 10-week study accurately, please create a unique 5-digit Personal Identifier Code (PIC):*
>
> - *First 3 Digits: Use the first three numbers of your hometown postal code.*
> - *Last 2 Digits: Use the first two letters of your favourite movie.*
> - *Example: 567LN.*
>
> *Your PIC will never be linked to your name or any personal contact information. It is essential to record this exact 5-digit code and remember it. You must use this same code for every survey in the study. Consistency is critical; if your code changes, we will be unable to link your longitudinal responses, and your participation data may become unusable."*

For **the specific case of in-person interviews**, to adhere to "Privacy by Design" principles**, audio files are renamed using a Personal Identifier Code (PIC) at the end of the interview session.** The PIC is collected via a separate, secure online survey filled out by the participant at the time of the interview; this survey records the PIC and the timestamp of the meeting. The PIC will then be transcribed at the end of the entire interview, after the aTrain transcription. During transcription, any spontaneous identifiers (e.g., names, specific locations) are manually removed or replaced by the PIC.

4. How do we protect and safeguard your data?

In addition to "Privacy by Design," data security is maintained through the following measures:

1. ***Processor GDPR Compliance***
2. ***Data Minimization***
3. ***Strict Storage Protocols***
4. ***Local Security Measures***

Firstly, the data processors selected for the study were chosen to meet GDPR compliance requirements. **For each processor, GDPR compliance is ensured through:**

- ***Certification under the EU-U.S. Data Privacy Framework (DPF)****, ensuring a level of protection for personal data that is essentially equivalent to that of the EU (Microsoft and Qualtrics XM);*
- ***Data processing activities governed by the 2021 Standard Contractual Clauses (SCCs),*** *a pre-approved legal mechanism by the European Commission that contractually obligates Apple to maintain EU-standard privacy protections (Apple Inc.);*

For all these processors, referring to each processor's privacy statements serves as proof of GDPR compliance *and* as the basis for recognition of compliance. Please find these documents here: Microsoft, Qualtrics XM, Apple Inc. While Mistral and aTrain are formally GDPR-compliant, their privacy policies will not apply, as both models and software will be installed locally, with no data processing activity involving these processors.

Secondly, the **Data Minimisation procedure is applied through the limited data retrieval protocols outlined in the study's rationale.** No personal data beyond the specific scope and intent of the survey will be collected. If any unforeseen or incidental personal data is collected, it will be deleted or redacted immediately. Thus, no personal data that can be directly linked to a specific data subject will be stored. Finally, no secondary use of the data beyond the explicitly stated research objectives will be conducted; all processing remains strictly within the scope of the study.

Thirdly, **the repository/storage for all research data**, including processed transcripts and analytical entries, is stored on the EUI OneDrive cloud server within a restricted environment labelled the "Analysis Folder." This serves as the master repository for both raw and processed datasets. Access is strictly limited to the two joint data controllers and protected by EUI multi-factor authentication. Under the Standard Contractual Clauses between EUI and Microsoft, data is stored within the EU/EEA in full compliance with applicable data protection rules.

Certain applications used for collection and processing will also temporarily store data. Once this processing is complete, all output files and analytical results are transferred to the OneDrive Analysis Folder. All temporary storage phases constitute processing operations within the meaning of Art. 2(c) of the EUI Data Protection Policy. These processors include:

- ***Microsoft Teams*** *and* ***Apple Voice Memos*** *are used exclusively as temporary processing conduits. Files are transferred to the OneDrive repository immediately upon transcription completion and are not retained on these platforms.*
- ***Qualtrics XM*** *stores data throughout the study on servers located within the EEA to facilitate quantitative analysis.*

aTrain and **Mistral 2B** do not constitute data controllers as they operate locally on the data controllers' hardware (Apple Mac computers). The developers of these tools do not qualify as Data Processors, as they lack any technical capability to access, view, or transfer the data (Arts. 2(e) and 2(f) of the EUI Data Protection Policy). **Local security measures are applied to these local data processing operations**:

- ***Data Migration:*** *After processing, no data is saved locally on permanent hard drives; all files are immediately migrated to the secure EUI OneDrive cloud, ensuring no data "leaks" remain on the local machine;*
- ***Operational Security Practices:*** *The research team adheres to a strict "Clean Desk" policy and utilises screen-lock shortcuts whenever leaving the workstations;*
- ***Hardware Security:*** *Hardware is secured with 12-character alphanumeric passwords and FileVault Full-Disk Encryption enabled on macOS;*

5. How long do we keep your data?

The retention of personal data collected within the scope of this study varies by data category; a tiered retention schedule is thus established:

1. ***Pseudonymized Study Responses:*** Deletion five years after the conclusion of the research.
2. ***Raw Interview Recordings:*** Deletion immediately following transcription and pseudonymization.
3. ***Pre-study Contact Information:*** Deletion one year after the conclusion of the research.

The erasure protocol varies by storage medium to ensure permanent data destruction. Data stored through external processors (e.g., Qualtrics XM) is subject to complete server-side deletion once the research is completed. For local processing (e.g., Mistral AI and aTrain), data remains strictly within the secure EUI environment. On the EUI OneDrive, to ensure "true" deletion, the data controllers will manually clear both the primary and the "Second-stage recycle bin" to prevent any administrative recovery. To provide verifiable proof of data destruction, a *Data Retention & Destruction Log* will be maintained. This log, stored as a Microsoft Excel file within the

secure analysis folder, will contain no personal identifiers. For every erasure event, the log will record the Subject ID, timestamp, operator, and methodology.

6. How can you verify, modify, or delete your data?

If you wish to verify which data are stored, or you wish to access, correct, or delete your personal data, please contact the Data Controller(s) at:

- Vladimir.Sucha@eui.eu
- Antoine.cerqueira@eui.eu

You will receive a reply within 30 working days of receipt of the request. Remarks concerning this Privacy Statement can be addressed to data_protection_officer@eui.eu.

7. Right of recourse

According to Article 16 of the EUI's Data Protection Policy, [*research interview and/or survey*] participants enjoy the following rights concerning their personal data:

a) to be informed whether, how, by whom and for which purpose they are processed;
b) to ask for their rectification, in case they are inaccurate or incomplete;
c) to demand their erasure in case the processing is unlawful or no longer lawful ('the right to be forgotten');
d) to block their further processing whilst the conditions under points b) and c) above are verified.

If you consider that your rights under the EUI Data Protection Policy have been infringed as a result of the processing of your personal data, you have the right to request a review according to Article 27 of the EUI's Data Protection Policy. Such requests should be addressed to the Data Controller, who shall reply within 30 working days:

- Vladimir Sucha (Vladimir.Sucha@eui.eu)
- Antoine Cerqueira (Antoine.cerqueira@eui.eu)

Any request should be sent at the same time to data_protection_officer@eui.eu.

With reference to the information provided above in the Privacy Statement for the research project "*AI Use and Human Agency in Graduate Education*" please fill in the below Consent Form.

Consent Form for research project 'AI Use and Human Agency in Graduate Education'

I, the undersigned _____ *[state clearly your name and surname]*, hereby

agree ☐

do not agree ☐ *[please tick as appropriate]*

to participate in the research project ***'AI Use and Human Agency in Graduate Education'***, conducted by *Vladimir Sucha and Antoine Cerqueira* from the *European University Institute (EUI)* in Florence, Italy.

1. I have received sufficient information about this research project and understand my role in it. The purpose of my participation in this project and the future processing of my data has been explained to me in a comprehensive manner.

2. My participation in this project is completely voluntary. There is no explicit or implicit coercion whatsoever to participate.

3. Participation involves being interviewed by the researcher(s) from the European University Institute. The three total interviews will last approximately 20 minutes across ten weeks.

4. I consent to the researcher(s) taking notes during the interview.

5. I consent to the interview and the subsequent dialogue to be recorded by audio device.

6. I understand that I have the right to refuse and decline from answering questions.

7. I understand that if I feel uncomfortable in any way during the research interview and/or survey, I have the right to withdraw my consent and discontinue my participation.

8. I understand that I am fully entitled to withdraw my consent and discontinue the research interview and survey at any point.

9. I understand that I have the right to ask for the data collected prior to the withdrawal to be deleted, as long as it is not yet anonymised, and it is technically feasible to identify my research interview and survey responses.

10. I have been explained in detail how the researcher will use my personal data and I

    agree ☐

    do not agree ☐

    to be identified by my name in any of the outputs of this project using information obtained from this research interview and survey.

11. I understand that all personal data will be processed in full compliance with the EUI Data Protection Policy.

12. I understand that this research project has been reviewed and approved by (xxxx) and by the EUI Ethics Committee. The EUI Ethics Committee may be contacted [ethics@eui.eu] for any questions concerning research ethics. For any questions concerning data protection, the DPO of the EUI may be contacted [data_protection_officer@eui.eu].

13. I have carefully read and fully understood the statements in this form. All my questions have been answered to my satisfaction, and I voluntarily agree to participate in this study.

14. I have obtained a copy of this consent form co-signed by the interviewer.

In accordance with data protection regulations in force at the EUI and for further information on the EUI's Data Protection Policy, you may consult the following link:
Data protection web page: Data Protection at the EUI.

_____ _____

Signature of the participant Date

_____ _____ _____

Signatures of the researchers Date